

Definitions of power

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A working list of definitions.

Power

Power is the capacity to bring about outcomes — by acting directly, by shifting another agent's behaviour, by setting the conditions under which others act, or by producing agents and possibilities that didn't exist before. It comes in five overlapping forms. The English word "power" smears across all five; pulling them apart is most of the work.

Power-to

Power-to is the capacity to act — to do, to make, to bring something about — independent of any relation to another agent. A solo inventor who builds a working prototype has power-to without exercising power over anyone. It is the substrate of the other forms: you can't shift B's behaviour, sustain a structure, or write the rules without first being able to act. When people demand "more power" in their own lives, they usually mean this.

Agentic power

Agentic power is the capacity of one agent (or coordinating collective) to shift another agent's behaviour toward outcomes the first prefers, against the second's resistance, across some domain. A has power over B in domain D to the degree that B's behaviour tracks A's preferences more than it would in A's absence — no counterfactual gap, no power. It is capacity, not exercise: an unfired gun is still a threat. And it is always over some set of choices; a landlord has power over where a tenant sleeps but not over what they read.

Structural power

Structural power is the capacity of a system — a market, a bureaucracy, a body of law, a norm, a piece of infrastructure — to shift agents' behaviour against their preferences, without any agent willing the shift. The observable signature matches agentic power, but the counterfactual differs: for agentic power, removing A restores B's freedom; for structural power there is no A to remove. A worker taking a low wage is coerced not by their employer but by the labour market — a structure with no author. It is invisible by default: those living inside it experience the constraint as a fact of the world rather than a thing being done to them.

Constitutive power

Constitutive power is the capacity to set the structure that other agents then operate inside — to write the rules, pick the defaults, design the platform, draw the map. It is agentic in form (someone wills the structure into existence) but its effect runs through structural power (once embedded, it shifts behaviour without further input). It's the bridge between the two, and the highest leverage per unit effort: setting a structure shifts every interaction it mediates, for as long as it lasts. It then decays into structural power with no author — which is why old constitutive choices are so hard to undo.

Generative power

Generative power is the capacity to produce new agents, capacities, desires, identities, or possibilities — to bring into existence things that weren't there before, rather than to shift, constrain, or arrange what already is. The other four forms operate on a given set of agents and options; generative power changes that set. It runs the other way from the standard image of power: it gives you wants and self-conceptions you wouldn't otherwise have had. It is the

hardest to resist — by the time you can identify yourself as its subject, it has already made the “you” who would resist.

Egalitarianism

An egalitarian society is one that simultaneously raises the floor of power-to, caps concentrations of power-over, distributes constitutive power broadly, and biases structural power toward enabling rather than constraining. Four dials, not one — a society that wins on any single dial while losing on the others is not egalitarian. The floor, not the average, is what matters for power-to; power-over is capped rather than eliminated, since the target is to prevent domination, not to abolish authority; the rule-writing is distributed, the dial most often left out and the one that quietly determines the others. The dials have to move together or they undo each other.

Legitimacy

Legitimacy is the property that makes power voluntarily accepted by those subject to it. Legitimate power runs on compliance; illegitimate power runs on enforcement. It is a property power can have, not a sixth form — any of the kinds above can be legitimate, illegitimate, or contested. Two senses routinely get confused. *Descriptive legitimacy*: those subject to A’s power actually accept it as rightful, a fact about beliefs and behaviour. *Normative legitimacy*: A’s power meets some external standard — consent, procedural fairness, justice — a claim about what power ought to be acceptable. The two come apart in both directions: a regime can be widely accepted yet unjust by any defensible standard (most stable tyrannies), or normatively legitimate yet rejected on the ground (most failed reform projects).